BEASTS OF BOLLYWOOD

The celebrated creatures of Bollywood's horror flicks

THAKUR

Jaani Dushman (1979)

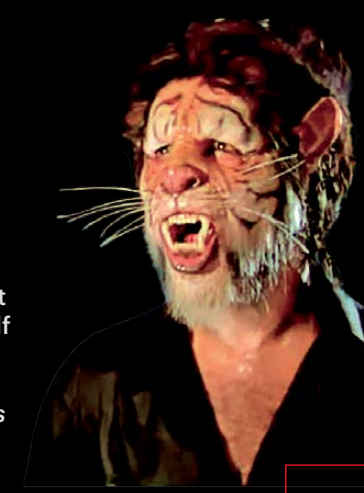
One of the earliest monsters in Hindi cinema, Sanjeev Kumar plays a man who when possessed by an evil spirit turns into a hirsute ape-like giant that preys on newly-wedded brides



TIGER

Junoon (1992)

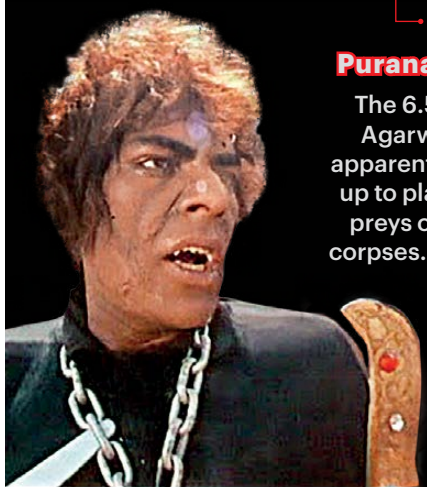
Filmmaker Mahesh Bhatt gave the classic werewolf a desi twist when Rahul Roy's character turns into a tiger every *amavas ki raat* (new moon day), thanks to a curse



SAAMRI

Purana Mandir (1984)

The 6.5-foot-tall Anirudh Agarwal (credited Ajay) apparently needed no make-up to play the *shaitaan* who preys on women and eats corpses. Agarwal would later also play Nevla (in *Bandh Darwaza*), a vampire who transforms into a bat and hunts humans



MANJULIKA

Bhool Bhulaiya (2007)

Vidya Balan's spooky turn as a malevolent woman is still a source of memes and even the odd prank. Balan is said to reprise the character in the upcoming part III



why he begins the shoot each day blasting a Hindi film song, preferably an obscure one from the 1990s, and has the cast and crew dance to it to begin the day on an uplifting note.

The man at the helm of the story, dialogues and screenplay is Niren Bhatt, a civil engineer-turned-IT consultant-turned-writer. Banerjee, who sees himself as the lucky, chosen one since his character Jana features in both the *Stree*s as well as *Bhediya*, calls Kaushik and Bhatt the "new-age gangsters in the film industry". Kaushik has the most fun on set and Bhatt may appear "Gulzar-ish" but deep down is a funny guy. "They are totally doing something that everybody's oblivious to," he says. "I am close to both, but sometimes even I am surprised by their imagination."

A proud fanboy of Gulzar and Ghalib and an admirer of Stephen King's Dark Tower series (*Gun Slinger* is a favourite), Bhatt says the idea of creating a horcom universe first came to them when he was writing *Bhediya* during the pandemic. Bhatt embellishes the fear-inducing moments with what he calls "banana peel" humour, like when Jana is left alone by his friends, his predicament evoking laughs among the audience. There's also wordplay, slapstick comedy and silly pop culture nods. "The beauty of this genre is that unlike drama, horcom is a medium for spontaneous reaction from audiences," says Bhatt. "It is a community experience. You watch it with more people to get the full joy out of it." The social message that imparts purpose to the genre is delivered "through visual metaphors and satire". So, the wolf in *Bhediya* acts as a vehicle to highlight the conflict between natives and outsiders and depleting forests courtesy rapid industrialisation. "You have to show them [the audience] the mirror, but the message has to be conveyed not by berating or screaming at them," adds Kaushik.

SCARED SILLY

Well-done horror films get a laugh out of you to cope with the jitters that must follow. Poorly-done ones do so for their shoddy visual effects and nonsensical ways. Even the Ramsay Brothers, pioneers of the genre in the 1970s and '80s, felt the need for a breather in their campy outings filled with ghastly monsters, graveyards, witchcraft, fog and lightning and mansions with stuffed heads of animals and gothic statues. Author Shamya Dasgupta in